Calcutta 200 miles to Sirajganj Ghat and Santahar and another 40 miles to Parbatipur. Metre-gauge lines run east from Santahar and Parbatipur to northern Assam; from East Bengal eastward from a Brahmaputra river ferry connection with the Santahar branch and northward from Chittagong to a junction with the main line at Lumding; barge lines on the Brahmaputra; combinations of rail and barge using various trans-shipment points along the river .

Problems: Informal Operations

In India the road was generally thought of as running from upper Assam westward and southward because its main traffic was in that direction—the hauling of tea to market. The war threw this railroad into reverse with the movement of the goods of war to China and Burma from Calcutta's port. The metre-gauge line of Parbatipur was in the main single track, fitted chiefly with rolling stock of the four-wheel type and powered by an assortment of locomotives made in Germany, England, Belgium, France and Czechoslovakia.

The Indian method of operation was friendly and informal—though often protracted. There were schedules, of course, but they were observed in the manner of a timeless land. Although a train might arrive at a station hours late, if the schedule called for a fifteen-minute stop, the full stop was observed, even though loading and unloading might take only two minutes. Efforts were made to step up the efficiency and capability of the railroad.

Improving Efficiency Greatly

On 23 December Major General W.E.R. Covell of SOS gave orders establishing the Military Railway Service. Headquarters were ordered at Gauhati, Assam. Units were assigned to operate the 752 miles of railroad. On 26 February orders were given by Covell that the Military Railway Service would assume operations one minute after midnight on 1 March. When the US railroaders took over, they found the Indians unfamiliar with railroad operation in the western world, and equipment in a bad state of repair. Rolling stock was coupled at times with wire! Indians secured vehicles on flat cars at times with twine of a strength that would make American binder twine appear strong as a log chain!

Communications, dispatching and phone circuits were poor. Most of the line was single-tracked with short sidings. There were bottlenecks, the Amingaon-Pandu ferry near Gauhati being an example. Cars headed one way could not be spotted until those coming across the ferry had gone on their way. There were not enough ferries and tugs to move them.

The Army ordered 10,000 War Department cars, double capacity of the Indian four-wheel 'wagons', which eventually tripled rolling stock capacity. The B&A had 73 locomotives, 401 being metre-gauge, 154 of them US lend-lease engines. By March 1945 there were 442 metre-gauge locomotives, of which 262 were War Department types. Ancient equipment had to be discarded and locomotives borrowed earlier had to be returned to other Indian roads.

Lack of sidings placed a limit on the speed of two-way traffic. Short sidings limited the length of trains. In the first year of operation, 30 sidings east of the Brahmaputra river crossing—the Amnigaon -Pandu ferry—were lengthened, and 37 more were in process, so that instead of taking an average of 50 cars, they could handle more than 100. West of the river the work was completed—26 lengthened to 4,000 feet each to accommodate 158 cars on the four-wheel car basis. Siding improvement work allowed reduction of block sections